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Grant Writing Masterclass

Module 6 — Proving You Can Deliver

Student Course Companion

Name: _____ Organization: _____

Team / Cohort (if applicable): _____

This workbook is your hands-on companion to Module 6. We move from argument to execution — showing a funder not just that you have a good idea, but that you know exactly how to deliver it. Complete each section in order. Team prompts appear in green throughout.

Section 1 — Key Terms & Concepts

These are the core concepts for Module 6. Each one maps to a specific section of your proposal.

Description of Activities	The section of your proposal that describes what your program actually does — each funded component, whether it is new or ongoing, how long it runs, why you chose it, and what research supports it. Your program blueprint.
New vs. Ongoing Activity	A distinction funders need to know: is this component something you are launching for the first time (expansion), or something you are continuing (sustaining)? Both are valid. Be explicit about which one the funder is investing in.
Best and Promising Practices	The evidence base that supports your program's approach. Funders want to know your model is grounded in something beyond instinct — that other organizations have used similar strategies and the results support them.
Best Practices Continuum	A spectrum from no research base to scientifically-based best practice. Your job is to identify where your program honestly sits on this continuum and present it clearly, with citations.
No Research Base	The program approach has not been evaluated by outside

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Promising Practice	entities. Not a disqualifier, but requires strong track record and outcome data to compensate.
	Approaches that have shown positive results in multiple settings, with some supporting evidence, even if a full rigorous research base does not yet exist.
Research-Based	Outside entities — universities, government agencies, or national funders — have published information supporting the effectiveness of the approach. You can point to a specific source.
Scientifically-Based Best Practice	The gold standard. Multiple rigorous studies demonstrate effectiveness. Often associated with federal clearinghouses such as What Works Clearinghouse or SAMHSA's NREPP.
Timetable	A section of your proposal that breaks your program into phases or milestones — staff hiring, program launch, mid-point evaluation, reporting, and close. Signals to funders that you are organized and realistic about what delivery requires.
Program Blueprint	A useful frame for the Description of Activities: think of it as the floor plan of your program. Every component is described with enough detail to be credible, but not so much that it buries the reader.

Section 2 — Annotated Example

Read the annotated proposal excerpt below. The right column explains what each element is doing and why it works. As you read, identify which techniques your own proposal uses and which ones are missing.

Sample: Goal, Activity Description, and Research Citation

PROPOSAL TEXT	WHY IT WORKS
[GOAL & OBJECTIVE] <i>Program Goal: To nurture and stimulate youth in a safe environment in order to reduce the effects of being latch-key.</i> <i>Specific Goal: To increase the language skills and cognitive abilities of youth participants while they</i>	→ Goal is directional — names the population and the intended change → Specific goal narrows the type of change expected (language + cognitive) → Objective adds the measurable target (90%), the outcome, and the

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participate in positive activities at the Youth Opportunity Center. <i>Objective: 90% of youth will know their career objectives and the appropriate path to attain them, as measured by a career readiness assessment administered at program entry and exit.</i>	assessment tool — all three required
[ACTIVITY DESCRIPTION] <i>The Career Exploration Workshop is an ongoing component of the YOC model, offered in 10-week cohorts throughout the school year. Each cohort meets twice weekly for 90-minute structured sessions. Participants complete a career interest inventory at intake, then engage in job shadowing, industry panel presentations, and résumé development. This format was chosen based on research demonstrating that extended, structured career exposure programs — rather than single-session interventions — produce significantly greater gains in career self-efficacy among adolescents (Lapan et al., 2012, Journal of Career Development).</i>	→ States: ongoing (not new) → Duration is specific: 10-week cohorts, twice weekly, 90-minute sessions → Explains why this format was chosen — not just what it is → Cites a named study with author, year, and publication — turns this into a research-based program
[TIMETABLE EXCERPT] <i>Month 1: Hire and onboard program coordinator. Month 2: Launch intake and first cohort. Month 4: Conduct midpoint career readiness assessment. Month 6: Submit interim funder report. Month 9: Final cohort closes; administer exit assessments. Month 10: Complete independent evaluation and submit final report.</i>	→ Phased milestones show the funder the full arc of delivery → Staff hiring is first — realistic sequencing → Evaluation and reporting milestones are built in — accountability is baked into the plan

□ **Team:** As a group: look at the activity description example. Which of the four required elements (new/ongoing, duration, rationale, research) does your organization's current program description include? Which ones are missing?

The Best Practices Continuum — Reference Guide

Use this table as a reference when positioning your program's research base. Find where your program honestly sits and use the guidance to present it accurately and compellingly.

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Level	What It Means & How to Present It
No Research Base	The program approach has not been evaluated by outside entities. No published studies support the model. Requires strong track record and outcome data to compensate.
Promising Practice	The approach has shown positive results in multiple settings. Some evidence exists, though a full rigorous research base has not yet been established. Cite early studies or multi-site evaluations.
Research-Based	Outside entities — universities, government agencies, national funders — have published information supporting the effectiveness of this approach. You can point to a specific source.
Best Practice Model / Blue Ribbon	Rigorous evaluation in multiple settings has consistently shown strong outcomes. The program may hold a formal designation from a credentialing body or federal agency.
Scientifically-Based Best Practice	The gold standard. Multiple randomized or quasi-experimental studies demonstrate effectiveness. Often associated with federal clearinghouses such as What Works Clearinghouse or SAMHSA's NREPP.

□ **Tip:** Find the research in your field that is furthest along this continuum and use it. If your program aligns with a scientifically-based model, say so and cite it. If you are working from promising practices, name them. Accuracy and confidence together signal that you understand your field.

□ **Where does your program currently sit on the continuum? Name at least one specific research source, study, or model program that supports your approach.**

□ **Team discussion:** Assign each team member a different source to research before the next session: a federal clearinghouse (What Works Clearinghouse, SAMHSA NREPP), a university study, a national nonprofit report, and a government agency publication. Bring citations to compare.

Section 3 — Before & After Comparisons

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Study each pair. The weak version shows what most first drafts look like. The strong version shows what wins funding. Answer the reflection question after each pair.

Comparison 1 — Activity Description

☐ Weak

We will provide tutoring services to students after school. Our staff will work with students on their homework and help them improve their grades. This is an ongoing program.

☐ Strong

The After-School Academic Support Program is an ongoing initiative operating five days per week during the school year. Each 2-hour session includes structured homework assistance (45 minutes), one-on-one reading intervention using the Wilson Reading System (30 minutes), and STEM enrichment activities (45 minutes). This format was selected based on findings from the National Center for Education Evaluation (2019), which identified structured after-school academic programming with explicit literacy components as a promising practice for improving elementary reading outcomes in high-need schools.

- ☐ What four elements does the strong version include that the weak version omits?

☐ **Team discussion:** Pull up one of your organization's current program descriptions. Does it include all four elements? Assign someone to rewrite it using the strong version as a model.

Comparison 2 — Research Citation

☐ Weak

Research shows that mentorship programs are effective for at-risk youth. Studies have found that having a mentor makes a big difference in young people's lives. Our program is based on these best practices.

☐ Strong

Our mentorship model is informed by MENTOR's Elements of Effective Practice for Mentoring (4th Edition), which synthesizes findings from over 1,200 mentorship programs nationwide and identifies structured match support, regular check-ins, and

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minimum contact frequency as the strongest predictors of positive youth outcomes. Our program implements all three elements, with weekly mentor contact, monthly group check-ins, and a dedicated match support coordinator.

- **What makes the strong citation credible? What does it do that “research shows” cannot?**

□ **Team discussion:** *Identify one specific, named research source for each program component you plan to fund. If you cannot name a source, that is your research assignment before the next session.*

Comparison 3 — The Timetable

□ **Weak**

The program will begin in the fall and run through the spring. We will hire staff and launch the program. At the end of the year we will report our results to the funder.

□ **Strong**

Month 1 (October): Hire and onboard program coordinator and two part-time tutors. Month 2 (November): Complete intake assessments for 65 enrolled participants; launch program cohort. Month 5 (February): Administer midpoint reading assessments; submit interim funder report. Month 9 (June): Final assessments completed; independent evaluator delivers outcomes report. Month 10 (July): Final funder report submitted with full outcome data.

- **What does a phased timetable communicate to a funder that a vague timeline does not?**

□ **Team discussion:** *Map your program's key milestones as a group. Is the sequence realistic? Does your timeline match your budget and staffing capacity?*

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Section 4 — Your Proposal Builder

Complete each part below. This is the raw material for your actual proposal sections. The more specific you are here, the stronger your proposal will be.

Part A — Goals and Objectives (Sample Language)

Use the structure from the annotated example: overarching goal → specific goal → measurable objective.

☐ **Your overarching program goal (the big-picture change):**

☐ **Your specific goal (the type of change your program creates):**

☐ **Your measurable objective (percentage, population, timeframe, measurement tool):**

★Example — Objective structure:

By [date], [X]% of [# participants] who complete [program activity] will [specific measurable change], as measured by [assessment tool / data source].

☐ **Team:** *Test your objective together using the Five-Question Test from Module 5: How many? In whom? By when? How much change? Measured how? All five must be answerable before the objective is ready.*

Part B — Description of Activities

Complete the table below for each program component you are seeking funding for. Add rows as needed.

Activity Name	New or Ongoing?	Duration	Why This Activity?	Research / Evidence Source
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☐ **Tip:** For each activity, ask: why this one? Why this format? Why this duration? The reasoning is what builds funder confidence in your approach.

☐ For your most important activity, write a full paragraph description (3–5 sentences) that includes: new or ongoing, duration and format, rationale, and research citation.

☐ **Team discussion:** Share your activity descriptions as a group. Does each one answer all four questions? Is the research citation specific enough to be verifiable?

Part C — Best Practices Research

☐ Where does your program sit on the Best Practices Continuum? (Circle or write the level: No Research Base / Promising Practice / Research-Based / Best Practice Model / Scientifically-Based)

☐ List at least two specific research sources, named studies, or model programs that support your approach. Include author, year, and publication or organization where possible.

☐ Write one or two sentences you could include in your proposal that cite this research explicitly:

★**Example — Research citation in proposal language:**

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Our literacy intervention model is grounded in findings from the What Works Clearinghouse (2021), which identifies structured decoding instruction combined with extended practice time as a practice with strong evidence of effectiveness for students reading below grade level.

Part D — Your Program Timetable

Complete the timetable below. Adjust milestone labels to fit your program. Add rows for any additional milestones specific to your project.

Milestone	Target Date / Month	Responsible Staff / Role
Hire / onboard program staff		
Procure materials and supplies		
Program launch / first participant intake		
Midpoint participant assessment		
Midpoint funder report (if required)		
Final participant assessment / outcomes data collection		
Program close / final evaluation		
Final funder report submission		

☐ **Tip:** Review your timetable against your budget and staffing plan. If your timeline requires three new staff members, make sure your budget covers them. If your first cohort launches in Month 2, make sure Month 1 is reserved for hiring and onboarding.

☐ **Team:** Assign each milestone a responsible team member or role before leaving this session. A timetable without owners is a wish list, not a plan.

Section 5 — Module 6 Self-Audit Checklist

Check every box you can honestly say is true for your current proposal draft. Unchecked boxes are revision priorities before the next module.

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Goals and Objectives

- ☐ I have an overarching program goal that names the population and the big-picture change.
- ☐ I have at least one specific goal that names the type of change my program creates.
- ☐ Each objective includes a percentage target, a population, a timeframe, and a measurement tool.
- ☐ My objectives pass all five questions of the Five-Question Test.

Description of Activities

- ☐ For each funded activity, I have stated whether it is new or ongoing.
- ☐ I have described the duration and format of each activity with specific detail.
- ☐ I have explained why I chose each activity — not just what it is.
- ☐ Each activity description cites at least one specific, named research source.

Best and Promising Practices

- ☐ I have identified where my program sits on the Best Practices Continuum.
- ☐ I have at least two specific citations: author, source, and finding.
- ☐ My proposal language explicitly connects my program model to the research — not just vaguely references “best practices.”
- ☐ I have not overstated the evidence, and I have not understated it.

Timetable

- ☐ My timetable states whether the program is ongoing or has a defined start and end date.
- ☐ It includes at least six milestones: hiring, launch, midpoint assessment, interim report (if required), final assessment, and final report.
- ☐ Each milestone has a target date or month and a responsible role.
- ☐ My timetable is realistic relative to my budget and staffing capacity — no gaps or impossible sequences.

Proposal Coherence

- ☐ My activities directly address the needs I described in Module 5’s Needs Statement.
- ☐ My timetable is consistent with the program duration implied by my objectives.
- ☐ Everything in this module is consistent with my summarizing sentence from Module 5.

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My revision priorities before the next module:

☐ **Team:** Assign each revision item a team member and a due date. Write names next to each item above before leaving this session.

*“Vision gets attention.
Evidence and planning get funded.”*
— Grant Writing Masterclass, Module 6